



S. Europe

Basilica of San Vitale

A high point of Byzantine architecture in Italy, its interior is lavishly decorated with mosaics

The Italian city of Ravenna is home to a wealth of early Christian architecture, dating from the 5th and 6th centuries under successive Roman, Ostrogoth, and Byzantine rule. Among the eight buildings given UNESCO World Heritage status in Ravenna is the Basilica of San Vitale, an imposing octagonal structure built between 526 and 547 CE.

Renowned mosaics

Although not strictly a basilica in architectural form (the term refers to a rectangular building with a central nave and aisles), the church was granted the title in recognition of its ecclesiastical status. The architecture is a hybrid of Roman elements, such as the dome, and Byzantine influences—in particular, the octagonal floor plan and the use of bricks with a thick rendering of plaster. The rather austere exterior of the church, however, is misleading. Inside, the spacious polygonal nave is filled by natural light and is sumptuously decorated throughout with brilliant mosaics. These depict the saints and the life of Christ and commemorate the accession of the Byzantine emperor Justinian I and his wife Theodora as rulers of Ravenna.

△ BYZANTINE MOSAICS

The Basilica of San Vitale is decorated with uniquely well-preserved mosaics in the Hellenistic-Roman style. It also houses the most important collection of Byzantine art of the period.

▷ PANEL OF JUSTINIAN

On one wall of the apse is a mosaic panel depicting the Emperor Justinian with his court officials and clergy; opposite is a panel showing his wife, Empress Theodora.



▽ OCTAGONAL EXTERIOR

The typically Byzantine octagonal nave supports an upper tier with a dome. Flying buttresses are used to transmit the lateral, outward forces to the ground.

